Decode the body

Tiny word parts. Big clues about what is happening inside you.

QUICK GUESS / What might bradycardia mean?

brady- SLOW + cardi HEART + -ia CONDITION

REVEAL / A condition of an abnormally slow heart rate.

PREFIXES / front-of-word clues

PART	MEANING	SPOT IT
a-, an-	without; not	apnea: no breathing
brady-	slow	bradycardia: slow heart rate
tachy-	fast; rapid	tachycardia: fast heart rate
hyper-	high; excessive	hypertension: high blood pressure
hypo-	low; below normal	hypoglycemia: low blood glucose
poly-	many; much	polyuria: excessive urine output
oligo-	few; scanty	oliguria: low urine output
peri-	around	pericardium: around the heart
endo-	within	endoscopy: look inside the body
epi-	upon; above	epidermis: outer skin layer
intra-	within	intravenous: within a vein
inter-	between	intercostal: between the ribs
sub-	under; below	subcutaneous: under the skin
dys-	difficult; abnormal	dysphagia: difficulty swallowing
hemi-	half; one side	hemiplegia: paralysis on one side
bi-	two; both	bilateral: relating to both sides
uni-	one; single	unilateral: relating to one side

SUFFIXES / end-of-word clues

PART	MEANING	SPOT IT
-itis	inflammation	gastritis: stomach inflammation
-algia	pain	neuralgia: nerve pain
-ectomy	surgical removal	appendectomy: appendix removal
-otomy	surgical incision	tracheotomy: incision into trachea
-ostomy	create an opening	colostomy: opening into colon
-ology	study of	cardiology: study of the heart
-ologist	specialist	cardiologist: heart specialist
-pathy	disease; disorder	neuropathy: nerve disorder
-megaly	enlargement	cardiomegaly: enlarged heart
-emia	blood condition	anemia: blood condition
-uria	urine; urination condition	hematuria: blood in urine
-pnea	breathing	dyspnea: difficult breathing
-scopy	visual examination	colonoscopy: visual colon exam
-gram	record; image	electrocardiogram: heart tracing
-graphy	recording process	angiography: vessel imaging
-lysis	breakdown; separation	hemolysis: red-cell breakdown
-rrhea	flow; discharge	diarrhea: frequent loose stools
-rrhage	excessive flow; bleeding	hemorrhage: heavy bleeding
-oma	tumor; mass	lymphoma: lymph-cell cancer
-osis	condition; often abnormal	cyanosis: bluish discoloration

DID YOU SPOT IT?

-ectomy = remove / -otomy = cut into / -ostomy = make an opening

FUN FACT / Not every medical word has all three parts.

MINI CHALLENGE / Which ending means a surgical incision?

ANSWER / -otomy. An ostomy creates an opening; an -ectomy removes.

Clues in context

Body roots + quick physiology facts. Can you decode them before reading the reveal?

ROOTS / THE BODY-PART CLUES

ROOT	BODY PART	EXAMPLE
cardi/o	heart	cardiology
neur/o	nerve	neurology
cerebr/o	brain	cerebral
encephal/o	brain	encephalitis
oste/o	bone	osteoporosis
arthr/o	joint	arthritis
my/o	muscle	myopathy
derm/dermat/o	skin	dermatology
hemat/o, hem/o	blood	hematology; hemorrhage
gastr/o	stomach	gastritis

ROOT	BODY PART	EXAMPLE
enter/o	intestine	enteritis
hepat/o	liver	hepatitis
nephr/o	kidney	nephrology
cyst/o	bladder; sac	cystitis
pulmon/o	lung	pulmonary
pneumon/o	lung	pneumonia
angi/o	vessel	angiography
cyt/o	cell	cytology
hist/o	tissue	histology

PHYSIOLOGY / FOUR FAST FACT CHECKS

HEART + VESSELS

Tachycardia	fast heart rate
Bradycardia	slow heart rate
Cardiomegaly	enlarged heart
Pericarditis	inflammation around heart

BREATHING

Apnea	cessation of breathing
Dyspnea	difficult breathing
Tachypnea	rapid breathing
Hypoxia	low oxygen in body tissues

DIGESTION

Gastritis	stomach inflammation
Hepatomegaly	enlarged liver
Gastrectomy	surgical stomach removal
Dysphagia	difficulty swallowing

URINARY

Hematuria	blood in urine
Polyuria	excessive urine output
Oliguria	low urine output
Nephritis	kidney inflammation

LIGHTNING ROUND / Say the meaning, then peek

1. hypo- + -emia = low + blood condition => hypoglycemia: low blood glucose
2. peri- + cardi + -itis = around + heart + inflammation => pericarditis

FUN FACT / cardi/o + -ology becomes cardiology: the combining o drops before a vowel.

Educational reference only; terms can depend on clinical context.